The Battle for Prithviraj Chauhan

The release of *Samrat Prithviraj* reawakens a latent conflict between the Gujjars and Rajputs over the legacy of the historical figure

By VINAY SULTAN

Whose Prithviraj is he anyway? From the very day—September 19, 2019, to be precise—that the Akshay Kumar-starrer and Yash Raj Films production was announced to the day it was released in theatres—on June 3—a battle royale was on over the legendary 12th century king of the Chamhana or Chauhan dynasty, whose defeat at the hands of Muhammad Ghori in 1192 CE at the second battle of Tarain is believed to have brought the curtains down on Hindu rule in much of the subcontinent. Celebrated as much for his valour as for his daring in riding away with the enemy's daughter—Sanyogita, daughter of Jaichand of Kannauj—the warrior king's depiction in the Chandraprakash Dwivedi-directed film, *Samrat Prithviraj*, has exercised sections of the Rajput and Gurjar communities, and for various reasons.